



SAFE

Washing fruits, vegetables, and hands before eating or cooking helps get rid of germs that can make people sick. When food is clean, it is safer to eat. This simple step helps keep everyone healthy.

Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics



NOT SAFE

Mold on food is not just on the surface-mold roots can go deep inside. Some molds can make you really sick even if you only see a little fuzzy part. It's safest to throw away moldy jam because it can contain poisons.

Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics



IT DEPENDS

Sometimes food left out for a while can start to go bad. If the potato salad has only been out for a short time and doesn't smell funny or look strange, it might be okay. But if it's been a long time or if it smells bad or looks different, it's safer not to eat it. So, it depends on how long it's been out and how it looks and smells.

Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics



SAFE

This is safe because Grandma used fresh fruit and clean jars, and she made sure the lids were on tight and didn't move. This helps keep the peaches safe to eat.

Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits



NOT SAFE

This is not safe because the bulging lid and popping mean air got in or germs grew inside. The cloudy liquid and bad smell are signs the fruit is spoiled or has harmful germs. Eating this fruit could make someone very sick.

Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits



IT DEPENDS

Sometimes, the jar of fruit is safe to eat if it has something that helps keep it fresh and the lid is closed well. Other times, if that special thing wasn't added, tiny germs could grow inside, and the fruit might not be safe. When you're not sure if the fruit is safe, it's best to ask an adult before eating.

Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits



SAFE

If the lid is tightly sealed down and the jar smells fresh without any strange or bad smells, the salsa is safe to eat. The seal means air and germs couldn't get in, so the food stays good. Always check that jars are sealed well before opening.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



NOT SAFE

When a jar's lid looks all puffy and the food inside smells bad, it means germs might have grown inside. This food is not safe to eat because it can make you sick.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



IT DEPENDS

Leaving salsa out all night is risky because harmful germs can grow even if it looks and smells okay. If it was canned correctly and sealed well and is a tested recipe, then it might still be okay. But if it was not processed properly or the jar seal is broken, it's not safe.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



SAFE

Low acid foods like green beans need to be cooked in a special cooker called a pressure canner, which gets hotter than boiling water to kill all bad germs. If the jars are sealed tight and look normal with no strange smells or bubbles, they are safe to eat.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game



NOT SAFE

Cooked low acid foods like potatoes left out at room temperature too long let bad bacteria grow that can make people very sick. If they smell bad, it's a sure sign bacteria have started making poisons. These foods should be thrown away.

Source: PNW 450 Canning smoked fish at home



IT DEPENDS

A popped lid or mold on canned low acid foods usually means the food might not be safe. But if the mold is only on the outside and no bad smells or bubbles are inside, an adult might be able to carefully clean it off and check. If the food smells funny, is discolored, or if the lid is bulging, it must be thrown away to stay safe.

Source: PNW 450 Canning smoked fish at home



SAFE

When a jar lid is sealed tight and pressed down in the center, it shows the pickles are safely preserved. Clear liquid and a fresh vinegar smell mean the pickles are good to eat. Always check for a strong sealed lid and no mold or bad smells before eating pickles from a jar.

Source: SP 50-466 Pickle fact sheet



NOT SAFE

Leaving pickles without a lid on the counter for days lets germs grow. Slimy cucumbers and bad smells mean the pickles went bad and could make you sick. Always keep pickles in the fridge with a lid to stay safe.

Source: SP 50-834 Tips for critical thinking



IT DEPENDS

Sometimes tiny white fuzzy spots can grow even in the fridge, but that might mean the pickles are not safe anymore. If you see fuzzy stuff, smell something funny, or the jar lid isn't closed tightly, it's best to tell an adult and not eat the pickles. But if the jar is closed tightly and everything else looks and smells okay, sometimes grown-ups carefully take off the fuzzy part and keep eating the rest.

Source: UC Davis Common issues with fermented fruits and vegetables



SAFE

When jam jars have tight lids and the jam looks clean and fresh, it is safe because there are no signs of mold or spoilage. Keeping jam in the fridge after opening helps stop germs from growing. When jam is made and stored well, it's a yummy and safe treat.

Source: SP 50-765 Low sugar fruit spreads



NOT SAFE

When the jar lid is popped up, it means air can get inside, and that lets mold grow. Mold on jelly can make people feel sick. Even if just a little mold shows, it can be all through the jelly. It's safest to throw away jelly that has mold or a lid that is popped up.

Source: SP 50-934 USDA molds on food



IT DEPENDS

If grape jelly smells sour or funny, it might be starting to spoil because it was left out too long. But sometimes jelly can smell a little different and still be safe if it was sealed well and cooled quickly. It's safest to ask an adult to check for other signs like mold or bubbles before eating.

Source: SP 50-934 USDA molds on food



SAFE

When frozen food is kept at the right cold temperature, it stays safe to eat. If the freezer door is closed and the food looks and smells normal, it means the food was stored properly and won't make you sick.

Source: PNW 214 Freezing fruits and vegetables



NOT SAFE

Leaving foods with meat or cheese out at room temperature for many hours lets bad germs grow quickly. Eating it could give you a tummy ache. Foods with meat or dairy must be kept cold until eaten.

Source: PNW 296 Freezing convenience foods that you've prepared at home



IT DEPENDS

The frost and mushy feel mean the berries might have freezer burn, which can change taste and texture but usually does not make you sick. If they don't smell bad or look moldy, they are safe to eat but might not taste as good.

Source: PNW 214 Freezing fruits and vegetables



SAFE

Jerky is safe to eat when the meat is heated to the right temperature before or right after drying. This kills germs that can make you sick. Drying the meat until it is dry helps keep it safe to store without spoiling.

Source: PNW 632 Making jerky at home safely



NOT SAFE

Fish has to be cooked or smoked until it is hot enough all the way through to kill germs that can make people sick.

Smoking fish without reaching that safe temperature can let dangerous germs stay alive. Eating fish that isn't cooked enough is not safe.

Source: PNW 238 Smoking fish at home



IT DEPENDS

Drying fruit is safe if it stays clean and dry, but if insects land on it or it gets dirty, it might have germs that can cause sickness. It depends on whether the fruit stays protected from bugs and dirt and dries well. If you see any mold, bad smell, or bugs, it is not safe.

Source: PNW 397 Drying fruits and vegetables